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Is beauty good for the soul?

(and what does that even mean?)

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Introduction

Beauty is messy. It's something the existence of which is almost universally acknowledged, but no one can successfully define. For example, Dictionary.com goes for "the quality present in a thing or person that gives intense pleasure or deep satisfaction to the mind, whether arising from sensory manifestations (as shape, colour, sound, etc.), a meaningful design or pattern, or something else (as a personality in which high spiritual qualities are manifest)." However, we can argue with this definition quite easily with the question of whether something has to be pleasurable to be beautiful?

Take this picture of Evelyn McHale on May 1st 1947:



It was taken only a few minutes after she jumped from the observation deck on the 86th floor of the Empire State Building in New York City.

The suicide note she left on the wall of the observation deck she jumped from read:

“I don’t want anyone in or out of my family to see any part of me. Could you destroy my body by cremation? I beg of you and my family — don’t have any service for me or remembrance for me. ~~My fiance asked me to marry him in June. I don’t think I would make a good wife for anybody. He is much better off without me.~~ Tell my father, I have too many of my mother’s tendencies.”

(the last sentence is referring to what we now know to be her mother’s undiagnosed and untreated depression)

It was described as “The most beautiful suicide” by Time magazine when they reported on the photo, and the name stuck.

The point I’m making by example is that if something as profoundly disturbing as this can become as famous as it has (referenced in works by David Bowie, Radiohead, Kanye West (speculated) and Taylor Swift) with the popular name “The most beautiful suicide ever”, then it’s simply not possible for beauty to be limited to pleasurable experiences only.

To really drive this point home, here’s some more eerily beautiful photographs of horrific things:

Vietnamese Buddhist Monk Thích Quảng Đức’s suicide by self-immolation to protest the persecution of Buddhists by the South Vietnamese government on the 11th June 1963:



A starving child, who was called Kong Nyong, being watched by a vulture while attempting to reach a UN food aid centre at Ayod, in what is now South Sudan. He did reach the food centre, but died from illness in 2007. This photograph was taken on an unknown day in March 1993.



Needless to say in light of this, Dictionary.com's definition is not fit for purpose.

I'm going to try to find one that is.

What can be argued to be beautiful?

I'm going to present this a subsection for each medium.

Art (of sorts)

Untitled

by Donald Judd



Untitled is best described as maximal minimalism. It is minimalism overdone as much as possible. Remove everything you possibly can. A title? Too much; remove it. A concrete block? Too much; make it out of arranged slabs instead so that there's physically less there.

My reading of this is that it could be one of two things:

- 1: Simply the question of how little can be considered art.
- 2: Commentary on the state of modern architecture, as it does bear a striking resemblance to a lot of office blocks and other concrete monoliths that we find in post-industrial cities. It is reminiscent in many ways of how there is (or at least it feels like there is) no creative thought going into such buildings and how aggressively a lot of construction companies minimize material use, sometimes at the expense of structural integrity.

It's also very possible that there is nothing behind this and I'm just looking for something. However, I still found something valuable even if the artist didn't intend it.

It's also strangely beautiful – the way that the small stones used to make the concrete peek through despite the otherwise oppressive grey monotonous face of the structure and the way that the sunlight softens the colours on the structure and casts angular shadows.

Simultaneously though, It can be said that what I am finding beautiful is evoked feeling of “nature fighting back against human oppression”.

Striped Candles

by furniture company HAY



These striped candles are interesting because they are the antithesis to *Untitled*. Instead of a simple plain wax candle in a simple round holder (the most efficient and functional way to do it), many of the candles were poured in a spiralling form and in multiple colours. The holders are also non-circular shapes, which is far less efficient than the optimal circular form. The bases also have sections cut out in many cases, which is more work than necessary and requires the parts that are not cut out to be longer than in the circular case to maintain stability.

All this is to say that the essence of maximalism is to go completely over the top with complexity. I've always liked the metaphor that proper maximalist art should feel like eating a sweetshop.

I also think these are beautiful, although I can't quite pin down what I like about them exactly. I think it's how, frankly, weird they are. I'm tired of the same plain wax candles in the same circular holders being everywhere.

Girl at a Window

by Rembrandt van Rijn



This is the extremely classical example that's effectively mandatory when trying to sample all of art in a limited number of pieces.

This is one of those rare artworks that I can't decide if I love or hate. The realism is undeniably impressive (it's said that Rembrandt hung this painting near a second floor window and people would wave at it) which makes it aesthetically pleasing, but I can't quite decide if it qualifies as beautiful. There are many imperfections — Rembrandt went far too overboard on the colours in many places, and the setting doesn't feel fully spatially coherent (Rembrandt's original sketch focused overwhelmingly on the human subject rather than the spatial environment she was in, so it makes full sense why this is the case.)

In essence, I really can't decide whether this is actually beautiful. I think the dealbreaker is that it's not sending a message to me. It's aesthetically pleasing painting from Rembrandt, but he doesn't have anything to tell me.

Everyone I Have Ever Slept With 1963-1995

by Tracey Emin



Everyone I Have Ever Slept With 1963-1995 is the perfect opposite to Rembrandt. Frankly, it's completely aesthetically ugly, but I don't think that immediately disqualifies it from being beautiful.

This is primarily because I think, like all of Emin's work, it's important. Emin herself stated directly that it's about "abortion, rape, teenage sex, abuse and poverty". The goal being to lure people in with the expectation that they'd learn about her sexual partners, and while that was true they'd also leave thinking about "who they've slept with, who they've been intimate with, who they've loved, who's hurt them, who abused them, who raped them."

It also raises questions about what is art. Is the goal of art purely to make people think, or is the fact that you can put a random object in a random art museum and people will stand and stare at it, looking for something that isn't there a reflection on the death of art as a field?

Again, I can't decide if this qualifies as beautiful or not.

Architecture

Subsections again:

Winchester Cathedral

Designer Unknown



This is the mandatory extremely conventional feature but for the architectural medium.

It is, as to be expected, very much aesthetically pleasing. I don't think that's really up for debate.

The issue arises when I have to answer the question of whether it is beautiful. The result I end up getting is that I can sort of see it trying to tell me something about the power of God, but that's a message that I as a religion sceptic automatically disregard.

In other words, this is sort of beautiful, but tainted by the message of "you must obey" it was designed to send.

20 Fenchurch Street

by Rafael Viñoly



This is effectively just a distortion of the conventional building, and I have to admit that I really like it.

Much like the candles, there is something I find really beautiful about this building.

I think it's this:

“Something that takes the convention and distorts it sends the message that the thing doesn't have to be this way. That's a message of progress. Progress is something that I really like.”

In other words, I see a message in 20 Fenchurch street that I really like, and that makes it beautiful, as long as I don't actively dislike the aesthetics of the thing in question.

Casa Milà

by Antoni Gaudí



Casa Milà is something I first studied in an art class at my previous school a long time ago.

I think it falls into the same place as the previous building, except that I actively like its aesthetics.

Bioscleave House

by Madeline Gins and Shusaku Arakawa



This is the most interesting building on my list.

The Bioscleave House in New York City was designed by Madeline Gins and Shusaku Arakawa in an attempt to create a house that would extend the lives of those living in it by as long as possible. For example, plug sockets were put as high up on the wall as the average person can reach, to get people to stretch more.

Unfortunately, this didn't turn out to be particularly effective.

However, there's something about such a bold but ultimately failed experiment that I can't help but be drawn to. I don't quite know if it constitutes beauty, but I'm still inherently drawn to it for some reason. I think it's the same thing as last time. A failed experiment is evidence that we learned something. Learning something is progress. I like progress.

Effectively, there is a kind of hidden message in this about the human attempt to survive for as long as possible, and how many times we have to fail for each time we make a breakthrough.

The insights we can draw from these

The question now is whether it's possible to find a common thread throughout all of these examples, and then whether it's possible to find a counterexample to that.

I think there is one, and it's twofold:

1: Anything that is beautiful must be aesthetically pleasing 2: Anything that is beautiful must send a message that resonates with the viewer.

So, can we find a counterexample?

The cyberpunk aesthetic

Here's a piece of cyberpunk art that's been in my photos app since the 18th February 2023



The counterexample that comes to mind is the concept of the cyberpunk aesthetic. The issue that this creates is that while it's massively aesthetically pleasing, it contains a message of societal decay and dystopia that I really don't like. What I mean by this that I've been a long believer in the idea of techno-optimism. The idea that technology and its development will make society better is one that I've long subscribed to, and I regard the idea that technology will make the world a worse place as a profoundly dangerous idea, as it makes us likely to willingly avoid progress because we are too scared of change. Despite how much I disagree with this idea, I still find everything to do with the cyberpunk aesthetic profoundly beautiful. In other words, it is a counterexample to the principles of beauty that I've previously outlined.

A metaphysical approach?

Effectively, we have established that there's no complete way to define beauty. I spent about a day picking and analysing those artworks and buildings, but it only took me five minutes to pick out a counterexample.

In other words, if we can't get to beauty through the more classical approach of looking for a common thread in beautiful things, then let's try looking at beauty as a concept in isolation.

How we can use Roger Scruton's ideas to get to the core of beauty

There's a lot to talk about in Beauty: A very short introduction (for example, the flaws in the beauty axioms Scruton provides is something I have effectively already covered without linking it to Scruton explicitly)

The thing I'm going to focus on (because I think it offers the key to the true answer about beauty) is this:

“According to this idea beauty is an ultimate value—something that we pursue for its own sake, and for the pursuit of which no further reason need be given. Beauty should therefore be compared to truth and goodness, one member of a trio of ultimate values which justify our rational inclinations.”

This approach is one that I find particularly interesting because it is one that Scruton kind of dismisses, at least in the short-term. However, I think there's a really good case for it.

Let me explain:

Scruton's argument against this concept of beauty is twofold.

- 1: If beauty is to be an ultimate value, it must be compatible with other ultimate values
- 2: The concept of ultimate values hinges on the existence of a god.

The critical issue with this is that it limits the concept of ultimate values to the thought system in which they were created. I think that it's entirely possible for ultimate values to exist, we just have to ground them in something that we know to be a truth.

The question now of course is “What is true?”

Assuming nothing else, it's pretty hard to argue against the idea that there are only two things that must be true.

- 1: We exist
- 2: There is nothing else we can possibly know.

I think we can ground ultimate values in the second one.

Let me explain:

The statement “there is nothing else we can possibly know” analogous to “we are limited in what we know”. If we are limited in what we know, then there must be things that exist that we do not know.

As a result, we can establish a kind of ultimate value, something that exists, but we cannot know.

Take truth, one of the ultimate values that Scruton mentioned, as an example. For everything of significance in day-to-day life, nothing can be proven beyond doubt to be true. (Hence is the reason why proof beyond reasonable doubt is the burden of proof in criminal cases, else no one would ever be convicted of anything)

However, that does not mean that there is nothing that is generally agreed upon to be true. For example, society would break down extremely quickly if it was not overwhelmingly agreed upon that “money has value” is true.

As a result, we can create levels of truth.

“True truth”, which is something that can be proven beyond doubt and Truth which can only be proven beyond reasonable doubt.

Hence, “True truth” must be an absolute value.

Hence again, we have reached a concept of absolute values without the use of a deity.

If ultimate values exist in this way, then beauty fits in perfectly as it is something that has a form that cannot be proven beyond reasonable doubt (and therefore should have a form that cannot be proven beyond doubt, yet we cannot really access it to tell).

In other words, objective beauty does exist, we just can’t access it and so we are left with an approximation.

So, is beauty good for the soul?

Whether beauty is good for the soul is a question that ties in quite nicely to the question we previously examined about the form of beauty.

If beauty has multiple forms, one absolute and one an approximation, I would argue that beauty is good for the soul, but only if we know how to handle it.

Let me explain:

Over the course of the conclusion on the nature of beauty, three arguments were examined.

1: Beauty is an absolute principle derived from God 2: We don't know what beauty is 3: Beauty is an absolute principle derived from reason.

In effect, humans have done in their approach to beauty exactly what Nietzsche predicted. We have started by explaining something with God, then gone insane at the unexplainable once we had killed him, and then finally discovered a new way to think about beauty that explains it without the need for a deity to patch over what we don't know.